

Harvest mouse

Micromys minutus

- ↔ 2–3 in (5–8 cm)
- 📍 W. Europe to E. Asia
- ⊗ Common

The tiny, reddish brown harvest mouse is specialized for climbing through tall grasses and other ground vegetation to feed on seeds, berries, and small insects. It is the smallest and lightest European rodent and the only one with a prehensile tail that it can wrap around a grass stem to support it as it feeds. It weaves a spherical nest of shredded grass, suspended above ground level by plant stems.



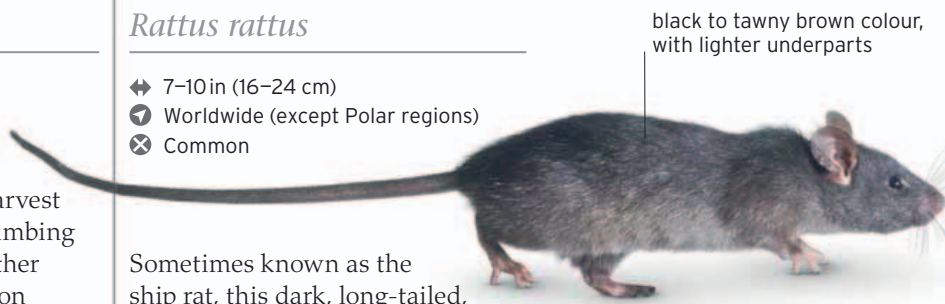
Black rat

Rattus rattus

- ↔ 7–10 in (16–24 cm)
- 📍 Worldwide (except Polar regions)
- ⊗ Common

Sometimes known as the ship rat, this dark, long-tailed, pink-footed rodent has been carried around the globe in ships' cargoes and now lives almost worldwide. Able to climb and swim well, it exploits urban habitats, where it often nests in roof cavities. It prefers plant matter, such as seeds and fruit, but will eat almost anything,

including carrion and human refuse. Black rats gather in "packs" of 20–60 and may intimidate larger animals such as dogs. This rodent's fleas are carriers of diseases such as bubonic plague, responsible for the deaths of millions of people in the past.



Brown rat

Rattus norvegicus

- ↔ 8–11 in (20–28 cm)
- 📍 Worldwide (except Polar regions)
- ⊗ Common

Bigger than the black rat, the brown rat favors damp habitats near or below ground level. It is extremely common in urban areas, where it often infests sewer systems. Mostly active by night, it is an opportunistic feeder on a variety of plant and animal matter and will even hunt in packs for live animals such as rabbits. Unlike the black rat, it does not transmit bubonic plague, but it does carry other human diseases and is a serious pest worldwide.

Spinifex hopping mouse

Notomys alexis

- ↔ 9–17 cm (3½–7 in)
- 📍 W. and C. Australia
- ⊗ Common

Named after the tough, spiky spinifex grass typical of its Australian desert habitat, this large mouse is well adapted for survival in the arid landscape. It conserves body fluids by producing very concentrated urine; this allows it to get all the moisture it requires from the leaves, berries, and seeds that it eats, so it never needs to drink water.

House mouse

Mus musculus

- ↔ 3–4 in (7–10.5 cm)
- 📍 Worldwide (except Polar regions)
- ⊗ Common

Like the black and brown rats, the house mouse has been unwittingly spread around the world by humans and thrives in artificial habitats. House mice live in family groups that multiply very fast, with females capable of producing 10 litters of up to eight young per year. The mice mark their territory with scent and urine, damaging any foodstuffs that they do not eat.



Lesser Egyptian jerboa

Jaculus jaculus

- ↔ 4–5 in (10–12 cm)
- 📍 N. Africa to W. Asia
- ⊗ Common

Also known as the desert jerboa, this rodent resembles a miniature kangaroo, with long hindlimbs that it uses to hop across the desert, balanced by its long, bushy-tipped tail. Its feet have broad pads of hair to stop them from sinking into the desert sand. It feeds at night on seeds and roots, and retreats to a burrow during the day, plugging the entrance to keep out the heat and predators.

North American porcupine

Erethizon dorsata

- ↔ 26–32 in (65–80 cm)
- 📍 Canada, US
- ⊗ Common



Covered with sharp, hollow spines, which can be up to 3 in (8 cm) long on its head, this rodent is adapted for climbing trees, with strong, broad feet and sharp claws to improve its grip. In winter, it feeds on conifer needles and bark, but in summer it also eats roots, leaves, flowers, seeds, and water plants. It is unusually vocal, especially during the courtship season, when it screeches, snorts, grunts, and hoots.

Brazilian guinea pig

Cavia aperea

- ↔ 8–12 in (20–30 cm)
- 📍 NW. to E. South America
- ⊗ Common

The probable ancestor of the domestic guinea pig (*Cavia porcellus*), but with a slightly more elongated body, this blunt-snouted, brown-furred rodent lives in shrubby grasslands across a wide swathe of South America. It feeds on a variety of leaves, grasses, flowers, and seeds, and also gnaws at bark. Guinea pigs share a feeding range, using communal runways through the grass, but each individual has its own nest.